

NATURE OF RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE

TWO-AXIS CONTROL – UNIVOCAL, EQUIVOCAL AND ANALOGICAL → SYMBOL, NEGATION AND INDICATION → COGNITIVE SPECTRUM → VERIFICATION AND FALSIFICATION → USE, SELF-INVOLVEMENT AND FORMS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g9 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

TWO-AXIS CONTROL

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RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE HAS TWO DISTINCT QUESTIONS

AXIS 1 — MODE OF PREDICATION

AXIS 2 — LOGICAL STATUS

“GOD IS GOOD” MAY BE ANALOGICAL AND COGNITIVE

“I COMMIT MYSELF TO GOD” MAY BE MEANINGFUL WITHOUT

NEVER MERGE HOW WORDS MEAN WITH WHETHER UTTERANCES ASSERT

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE HAS TWO DISTINCT QUESTIONS
- AXIS 1 — MODE OF PREDICATION: univocal

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- AXIS 2 — LOGICAL STATUS: cognitive/factual
- “God is good” may be analogical AND cognitive

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- “I commit myself to God” may be meaningful without describing an observable object
- NEVER merge how words mean with whether utterances assert facts.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.

01

STAGE 01

UNIVOCAL, EQUIVOCAL AND ANALOGICAL

UNIVOCAL, EQUIVOCAL AND ANALOGICAL

SAME MEANING FOR GOD AND CREATURES

CLARITY, BUT RISKS ANTHROPOMORPHISM

WHOLLY DIFFERENT MEANING

PROTECTS TRANSCENDENCE, BUT BLOCKS KNOWLEDGE/INFERENCE

RELATED MEANING GROUNDED IN CAUSAL PARTICIPATION

ANALOGY OF ATTRIBUTION/PROPORTIONALITY; CREATURELY GOODNESS REFLECTS DIVINE SOURCE

SOME UNIVOCAL CONCEPT OF BEING IS NEEDED FOR VALID

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

UNIVOCAL: same meaning for God and creatures → clarity, but risks anthropomorphism
EQUIVOCAL: wholly different meaning → protects transcendence, but blocks knowledge/inference

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

ANALOGICAL: related meaning grounded in causal participation
AQUINAS: analogy of attribution/proportionality; creaturely goodness reflects divine source

EVALUATION / TRAP

SCOTUS: some univocal concept of being is needed for valid reasoning about God tension: enough continuity for truth, enough difference for transcendence.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- UNIVOCAL: same meaning for God and creatures → clarity, but risks anthropomorphism
- EQUIVOCAL: wholly different meaning → protects transcendence, but blocks knowledge/inference

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- ANALOGICAL: related meaning grounded in causal participation
- AQUINAS: analogy of attribution/proportionality; creaturely goodness reflects divine source

EVALUATION / TRAP

- SCOTUS: some univocal concept of being is needed for valid reasoning about God tension: enough continuity for truth,
- enough difference for transcendence.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Scotus demands a minimal univocal concept for valid inference, while Aquinas insists that causal participation secures continuity without placing God and creatures in one genus.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Scotus demands a minimal univocal concept for valid inference, while Aquinas insists that causal participation secures continuity without placing God and creatures in one genus.

02

STAGE 02

SYMBOL, NEGATION AND INDICATION

SYMBOL, NEGATION AND INDICATION

SYMBOL PARTICIPATES IN THE REALITY IT DISCLOSES AND OPENS

VIA NEGATIVA

GOD IS NOT FINITE, COMPOSITE OR DEPENDENT

SUPEREMINENT TRANSCENDENCE

INDIAN “NETI NETI”

NOT THIS, NOT THIS; REMOVES FINITE OBJECTIFICATION

INDIRECT MEANING WHEN LITERAL SENSE FAILS LIMIT

TILLICH: symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality/self symbols are

VIA NEGATIVA: God is not finite, composite or dependent

PSEUDO-DIONYSIUS: affirmation → negation → supereminent transcendence

INDIAN “NETI NETI”: not this, not this; removes finite objectification

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- TILLICH: symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality/self symbols are living and can die; they are not arbitrary signs
- VIA NEGATIVA: God is not finite, composite or dependent

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- PSEUDO-DIONYSIUS: affirmation → negation → supereminent transcendence
- INDIAN “NETI NETI”: not this, not this; removes finite objectification

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- LAKṢAṆĀ/indication: indirect meaning when literal sense fails limit: pure negation must retain some positive orientation or reference disappears.
- TILLICH: symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality/self symbols are living and can die; they are not arbitrary signs

MECHANISM / VERDICT — For Tillich, a religious symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality and self otherwise inaccessible, but it must remain distinguishable from mere emotional projection.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: For Tillich, a religious symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality and self otherwise inaccessible, but it must remain distinguishable from mere emotional projection.

For Tillich, the symbol is not finite, composite or dependent

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religious symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality; religious symbols are living and can die; they are not arbitrary signs

MECHANISM / VERDICT — For Tillich, a religious symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality and self otherwise inaccessible, but it must remain distinguishable from mere emotional projection.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: For Tillich, a religious symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality and self otherwise inaccessible, but it must remain distinguishable from mere emotional projection.

03

STAGE 03

COGNITIVE SPECTRUM

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COGNITIVE REALISM

GOD-TALK STATES TRUTHS THAT MAY BE WARRANTED OR FALSE

LANGUAGE EXPRESSES A FORM OF LIFE, ORIENTATION OR CONSTRUCTION

ARTICULATES ATTITUDE/COMMITMENT

PRAYER, VOW, CONFESSION AND BLESSING DO SOMETHING

FORMS IDENTITY AND DISCLOSES A WORLD OF MEANING UTTERANCES

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EVALUATION / TRAP
COGNITIVE REALISM: God-talk states truths that may be warranted or false	EXPRESSIVISM: articulates attitude/commitment	MYTHIC/NARRATIVE: forms identity and discloses a world of meaning utterances can have several functions
ANTI-REALISM/NON-REALISM: language expresses a form of life, orientation or construction	PERFORMATIVISM: prayer, vow, confession and blessing do something	functional richness does not itself settle reference.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

• COGNITIVE REALISM: God-talk states truths that may be warranted or false

• ANTI-REALISM/NON-REALISM: language expresses a form of life, orientation or construction

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

• EXPRESSIVISM: articulates attitude/commitment

• PERFORMATIVISM: prayer, vow, confession and blessing do something

EVALUATION / TRAP

• MYTHIC/NARRATIVE: forms identity and discloses a world of meaning utterances can have several functions

• functional richness does not itself settle reference.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Non-cognitive theories clarify commitment and form of life, but they become reductive if they deny that believers also intend claims about reality.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-cognitive theories clarify commitment and form of life, but they become reductive if they deny that believers also intend claims about reality.

04

STAGE 04

VERIFICATION AND FALSIFICATION

VERIFICATION AND FALSIFICATION

COGNITIVELY MEANINGFUL FACTUAL CLAIMS MUST BE ANALYTIC OR EMPIRICALLY

TRADITIONAL GOD-TALK APPEARS MEANINGLESS, NOT MERELY FALSE

ESCHATOLOGICAL VERIFICATION — CELESTIAL-CITY PARABLE; CONFIRMATION MAY OCCUR AFTER

BELIEVERS LET “GOD LOVES US” DIE BY A THOUSAND

RELIGIOUS BLIK IS UNFALSIFIABLE ORIENTATION YET MEANINGFUL

PARTISAN TRUSTS STRANGER DESPITE COUNTER-EVIDENCE; COMMITMENT REMAINS EVIDENTIALLY TESTED

WHAT COUNTS AGAINST THE CLAIM, AND WHAT KIND OF

DOCTRINE / CLAIM	OBJECTION / PRESSURE	REPLY / RESIDUAL
• AYER: cognitively meaningful factual claims must be analytic or empirically verifiable • traditional God-talk appears meaningless, not merely false • HICK: eschatological verification — celestial-city parable; confirmation may occur after death	• FLEW: believers let “God loves us” die by a thousand qualifications • HARE: religious blik is unfalsifiable orientation yet meaningful • MITCHELL: partisan trusts stranger despite counter-evidence	• commitment remains evidentially tested key test: what counts against the claim, and what kind of claim is it?

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The verification and falsification debates test whether religious claims exclude any possible state of affairs; a meaningful theology must specify evidential risk without demanding laboratory verification.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The verification and falsification debates test whether religious claims exclude any possible state of affairs; a meaningful theology must specify evidential risk without demanding laboratory verification.

05

STAGE 05

USE, SELF-INVOLVEMENT AND FORMS OF LIFE

USE, SELF-INVOLVEMENT AND FORMS OF LIFE

MEANING IS USE WITHIN A LANGUAGE-GAME AND FORM OF

RELIGIOUS ASSERTIONS EXPRESS INTENTION TO FOLLOW AN AGAPEISTIC WAY

SAME WORD, DIFFERENT GRAMMAR

“FATHER” BIOLOGICAL/SECULAR

“FATHER” RELATIONAL RELIGIOUS USE

“CREATION” TEMPORAL MANUFACTURE

DEPENDENCE ON ULTIMATE SOURCE OBJECTION

WITTGENSTEIN: meaning is use within a language-game and form of life prayer, lament, confession and

BRAITHWAITE: religious assertions express intention to follow an agapeistic way of life

SAME WORD, DIFFERENT GRAMMAR

“father” biological/secular

SOURCE / DOCTRINE	ARGUMENT / MECHANISM	IMPLICATION / VERDICT
• WITTGENSTEIN: meaning is use within a language-game and form of life prayer, lament, confession and worship are not failed scientific hypotheses • BRAITHWAITE: religious assertions express intention to follow an agapeistic way of life • SAME WORD, DIFFERENT GRAMMAR	• “father” biological/secular • “Father” relational religious use • “creation” temporal manufacture	• dependence on ultimate source objection: use may explain intelligibility, but cannot by itself guarantee truth or protect critique.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Religious and secular language share grammar, but religious use is distinguished by its ultimate referent, self-involving force, communal practice and resistance to exhaustive literalisation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious and secular language share grammar, but religious use is distinguished by its ultimate referent, self-involving force, communal practice and resistance to exhaustive literalisation.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Religious and secular language share grammar, but religious use is distinguished by its ultimate referent, self-involving force, communal practice and resistance to exhaustive literalisation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious and secular language share grammar, but religious use is distinguished by its ultimate referent, self-involving force, communal practice and resistance to exhaustive literalisation.

06

STAGE 06

MYSTICISM, ADVAITA AND PLURALISM BRIDGES

MYSTICISM, ADVAITA AND PLURALISM BRIDGES

INEFFABILITY PRESSURES LITERAL DESCRIPTION; PARADOX AND SYMBOL POINT BEYOND

NIRGUṆA BRAHMAN BEYOND LIMITING PREDICATES; SAGUṆA LANGUAGE VALID EMPIRICALLY

DIFFERENT CONCEPTUAL SCHEMES MAY REFER TO OR CONSTRUCT DIVERSE

TRANSLATION WITHOUT ERASING DOCTRINAL DIFFERENCE ANSWER

COMPARE REFERENCE, PREDICATION, FUNCTION AND LIFE-CONTEXT SEPARATELY.

ADVAITA: nirguṇa Brahman beyond limiting predicates

→

saguna language valid empirically mahāvākya interpretation uses implication to remove incompatible literal attributes

→

PLURALISM: different conceptual schemes may refer to or construct diverse ultimates challenge: translation without erasing

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- MYSTICISM: ineffability pressures literal description; paradox and symbol point beyond concepts
- ADVAITA: nirguṇa Brahman beyond limiting predicates

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- saguna language valid empirically mahāvākya interpretation uses implication to remove incompatible literal attributes
- PLURALISM: different conceptual schemes may refer to or construct diverse ultimates challenge: translation without erasing doctrinal difference answer

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- compare reference, predication, function and life-context separately.
- MYSTICISM: ineffability pressures literal description; paradox and symbol point beyond concepts

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism.

07

STAGE 07

PYQ ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

PYQ ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

IDENTIFY UTTERANCE

ANALYSE MODE OF PREDICATION

CLASSIFY LOGICAL STATUS

NAMED THEORY (AQUINAS/TILlich/AYER/FLEW/HARE/MITCHELL/WITTGENSTEIN)

STRONGEST OBJECTION/REPLY

INDIAN ANALOGY OR NEGATION BRIDGE

RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE NEED NOT BE LITERAL TO BE MEANINGFUL

IDENTIFY utterance → analyse mode of predication → classify logical status

→

named theory (Aquinas/Tillich/Ayer/Flew/Hare/Mitchell/Wittgenstein)

→

strongest objection/reply → Indian analogy or negation bridge → verdict

→

CLOSE: religious language need not be literal to be meaningful, but analogy, symbol, use or

→

adequacy requires semantic intelligibility, critical vulnerability and lived function.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- IDENTIFY utterance → analyse mode of predication → classify logical status
- named theory (Aquinas/Tillich/Ayer/Flew/Hare/Mitchell/Wittgenstein)

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- strongest objection/reply → Indian analogy or negation bridge → verdict
- CLOSE: religious language need not be literal to be meaningful, but analogy, symbol, use or commitment cannot automatically secure factual truth

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- adequacy requires semantic intelligibility, critical vulnerability and lived function.
- IDENTIFY utterance → analyse mode of predication → classify logical status

MECHANISM / VERDICT — strongest objection/reply → Indian analogy or negation bridge → verdict

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: strongest objection/reply → Indian analogy or negation bridge → verdict.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

ADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

DOCTRINE STATEMENT.

PREDICATES SUCH AS GOOD AND WISE APPLY TO GOD

(1) CREATURES DEPEND CAUSALLY ON GOD AND DISPLAY PERFECTIONS

(2) EFFECTS RESEMBLE CAUSES WITHOUT MATCHING THEIR MODE

(3) PERFECTION TERMS CAN THEREFORE SIGNIFY TRULY WHILE THEIR

PRESUPPOSITION. CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

- Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- Doctrine statement.
- Predicates such as good and wise apply to God neither in exactly the creaturely sense nor in a wholly unrelated sense, but analogically.
- Argument.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

- (1) Creatures depend causally on God and display perfections
- (2) effects resemble causes without matching their mode
- (3) perfection terms can therefore signify truly while their mode of possession differs infinitely.
- Presupposition. CAUTION: Causal participation warrants semantic continuity and pure perfections can be separated from creaturely limitation.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

- Distinction.
- Analogy of attribution relates secondary instances to a primary source
- proportionality compares relations according to distinct modes of being.
- Canonical example.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.